GCSE History misconception bank

Causation, sources, and the topics pupils most often flatten. Optional units differ: swap the example, keep the mistake.

These are hinge questions for mistakes that come up again and again at GCSE. The topics are the ones pupils meet on AQA and Edexcel courses. They are not past papers, and they are not a mark scheme. Named texts, case studies and optional units differ by school. Swap the example. Keep the mistake.

Each wrong answer is a reason to reteach. The shaded box is for you. Cover it if the page is on the board.

34 hinges.

THE FIRST WORLD WAR · 1

The assassination of Archduke Franz Ferdinand in June 1914 is best described as

A. the trigger for the First World War, not the only cause.
B. the only cause of the First World War.
C. an event that happened after the war had already started.
D. the reason the Second World War began.

Correct: A.

B. A spark was promoted to the whole explanation.

C. The order was reversed. The assassination came first.

D. The two wars were collapsed into one.

Reteach: The shooting in Sarajevo set the July crisis moving. Alliances, empire and the arms race were longer-term. A trigger is not the whole cause.

CAUSATION · 2

Which of these can help explain the assassination of June 1914?

A. Tension in the Balkans before 1914.
B. The Treaty of Versailles in 1919.
C. The Battle of the Somme in 1916.
D. The Wall Street Crash of 1929.

Correct: A.

B. A later event was used as a cause. Versailles comes after the assassination.

C. Again the order is wrong. The Somme cannot explain 1914.

D. A crisis fifteen years later was dragged backwards.

Reteach: A cause has to come before the event. Put the dates in order before you let a pupil use one event to explain another.

CAUSATION · 3

A pupil says: “The First World War happened, so it had to happen.” What is the problem?

A. What happened was not the only way events could have gone.
B. There is no problem. If it happened, it was inevitable.
C. It means every person in Europe wanted a war.
D. It means the war had no causes.

Correct: A.

B. The outcome was treated as proof that nothing else was possible.

C. “It happened” was inflated into universal consent.

D. Rejecting inevitability was confused with rejecting causes. You still explain why it happened.

Reteach: Explain why a path became more likely. Do not treat the result as the only result there could have been. Ask what could have gone differently.

SOURCES · 4

A source is clearly one-sided. What follows?

A. It can still show what the author wanted people to believe.
B. It is useless and should be thrown out.
C. Every sentence in it must be factually false.
D. It is more reliable than a balanced source, because strong feeling is proof.

Correct: A.

B. Bias was treated as a reason to ignore the source.

C. One-sided was exaggerated into “all lies”.

D. Passion was treated as evidence of accuracy.

Reteach: Bias is a reason to be careful, not a reason to bin the source. A one-sided source is evidence of a point of view. Ask who made it, and what they wanted.

SOURCES · 5

A pupil quotes what a poster says and stops. What is missing?

A. Who made it, when, and why.
B. Nothing. The words are the whole of the source work.
C. Only the colours. Nothing about the maker matters.
D. A second identical copy of the same poster.

Correct: A.

B. Provenance was treated as optional.

C. A surface detail replaced the origin.

D. Duplication was confused with corroboration.

Reteach: Content is what it says. Provenance is where it comes from. You need both before you decide what the source is useful for.

SOURCES · 6

“The source says it, so it happened that way.” What is wrong?

A. A source can be mistaken, one-sided, or written to persuade.
B. Nothing. If it is written down, it is accurate.
C. Only photographs can be wrong. Writing cannot.
D. Only sources written at the time can be wrong. Later ones are safe.

Correct: A.

B. The existence of a source was treated as proof of its claim.

C. One type of source was given automatic trust.

D. Hindsight was treated as accuracy. Later accounts have problems of their own.

Reteach: Test the claim against who made the source and against other evidence. One voice is not the event itself.

INTERPRETATIONS · 7

Two historians explain the same event differently. What can that mean?

A. They asked different questions, or they weighed the evidence differently.
B. One of them must simply be wrong.
C. There is no evidence, so any answer is as good as any other.
D. The historian who wrote later is always right.

Correct: A.

B. Disagreement was treated as a mistake by one side.

C. A real disagreement was used to throw out the evidence.

D. Date of publication was treated as a mark of truth.

Reteach: Disagreement is normal. Look at the question each historian asked and the evidence they used. It is not a simple case of one winner.

CHANGE AND CONTINUITY · 8

A new ruler takes the throne. What can you say?

A. Some things change and some carry on. A new date does not reset ordinary life.
B. Everything in people’s lives changes on that day.
C. Nothing can ever change when a ruler changes.
D. Continuity means the event did not happen.

Correct: A.

B. A political event was treated as a total break.

C. Continuity was exaggerated into “no change at all”.

D. The word was emptied. Continuity is what stays, alongside what changes.

Reteach: Ask what changed, for whom, and what carried on. A new reign, law or war rarely changes every part of life at once.

SIGNIFICANCE · 9

A person is famous today. Does that make them historically significant?

A. Not on its own. Significance is about effects, and about the question you ask.
B. Yes. If the name is still known, the person changed the period.
C. No. A famous person cannot be significant.
D. Yes, if the person was liked.

Correct: A.

B. Fame was used as a substitute for consequence.

C. The two ideas were treated as opposites. Fame and significance can overlap. They are not the same test.

D. Approval was used as the test. Effects do not require popularity.

Reteach: Famous is about who is remembered. Significant is about consequences. Name the effect, and say for whom.

CAUSATION · 10

A pupil lists William's coronation as a cause of the Battle of Hastings. What is wrong?

A. The coronation came after the battle, so it is a consequence.
B. Nothing. The coronation caused the battle.
C. The battle and the coronation were the same event.
D. Causes and consequences are the same thing, so the label does not matter.

Correct: A.

B. The order was reversed. Hastings was 14 October 1066. The coronation was Christmas Day.

C. Two dates were collapsed.

D. The distinction pupils are asked to use was thrown away.

Reteach: A cause comes before. A consequence follows. Do not let a later event "explain" an earlier one. Check the dates.

NORMAN ENGLAND · 11

William won at Hastings on 14 October 1066. Which is right?

A. He was crowned at Christmas 1066, and serious rebellions continued, including in the north in 1069.
B. England was completely under his control the next morning.
C. He was never crowned.
D. The Harrying of the North happened before Hastings.

Correct: A.

B. A battle was treated as instant, total control.

C. The coronation was denied. It was Christmas Day 1066.

D. 1069 was placed before 1066.

Reteach: Hastings won him the crown. It did not bring instant quiet. The coronation was 25 December 1066. The Harrying of the North followed the revolt of 1069.

NORMAN ENGLAND · 12

What was Domesday Book for?

A. To record land and resources, so William knew what the kingdom could provide.
B. It was only a list of people's names.
C. It was a book of sermons.
D. Edward the Confessor had it made before 1066.

Correct: A.

B. A survey of land, stock and obligations was reduced to a register of names.

C. The name was taken literally, as a religious text rather than a survey.

D. The date was moved. The survey is 1086, under William.

Reteach: Domesday, compiled in 1086, surveyed manors: land, people and what they owed. It is evidence of Norman government, not a list of names and not a sermon.

MEDIEVAL ENGLAND · 13

When the Black Death reached England in 1348, what did people at the time know?

A. They did not know it was caused by bacteria. They used the explanations they had, including God's anger and bad air.
B. They knew it was bacteria and treated it with antibiotics.
C. They already had the modern germ theory and ignored it.
D. Deaths were not noticed, because nobody kept any record.

Correct: A.

B. Modern knowledge was given to the fourteenth century. Antibiotics did not exist.

C. A later theory was moved backwards by centuries.

D. The scale of the catastrophe was denied. People knew they were dying. They did not know the organism.

Reteach: Judge medieval responses by what people believed then. Bacteria were not known in 1348. Do not mark a fourteenth-century explanation wrong for failing a nineteenth-century test.

THE REFORMATION · 14

Why did Henry VIII break with Rome?

A. He wanted his marriage annulled, and a male heir. He did not begin as a Lutheran.
B. He had become a Lutheran and wanted a Protestant church from the start.
C. The Pope asked him to leave the Catholic Church.
D. England had no church before the Act of Supremacy in 1534.

Correct: A.

B. The trigger, the succession, was replaced with a conversion he had not made.

C. The conflict was inverted.

D. The break was treated as the invention of Christianity in England.

Reteach: The trigger was the annulment and the succession. The break was made by acts in the 1530s, including the Act of Supremacy in 1534. Henry stayed conservative on a good deal of doctrine. Do not call him a Lutheran convert.

ELIZABETHAN ENGLAND · 15

Why did the Spanish Armada of 1588 fail?

A. English ships, including the fire ships at Calais, and the weather both mattered.
B. It failed only because of a storm.
C. The fleet never left Spain.
D. It captured London, and then chose to go home.

Correct: A.

B. One cause was left to do the work of several.

C. The sailing was denied. It did leave, and it reached the Channel.

D. The outcome was reversed.

Reteach: The fire ships and the fighting off Gravelines mattered, and so did storms as the fleet went north around Scotland and Ireland. Do not reduce it to the weather.

INDUSTRIAL BRITAIN · 16

Which is a fair description of industrial change in Britain?

A. It was uneven. Some regions and trades changed earlier than others.
B. The whole of Britain became industrial in the same decade.
C. It happened in a single year and then stopped.
D. It only happened in London.

Correct: A.

B. A long, uneven process was squeezed into one moment, everywhere.

C. The pace was flattened.

D. The coalfields, the mills and the iron towns were left out. London was not the whole story.

Reteach: Cotton, coal and iron did not transform every county at the same pace. Ask where, and when. “The Industrial Revolution” is not one nationwide week.

INDUSTRIAL BRITAIN · 17

Which is right about factory work?

A. Children did work in mills and mines. They were not the whole workforce.
B. Every factory worker was a child.
C. Children never worked in the mills.
D. No law ever tried to limit children’s work.

Correct: A.

B. A real abuse was exaggerated into the entire labour force.

C. The abuse was denied.

D. The Factory Acts were erased. Limits came in stages. They did not end the work overnight.

Reteach: Say “children worked”, and say what that cost them. Do not say “only children worked”. Adults were the majority. Later Factory Acts limited child labour. They did not abolish it in a single clause.

THE FIRST WORLD WAR · 18

The First World War is best described as

A. a war on several fronts, including a long trench war on the Western Front.
B. only a trench war in France and Belgium, and nowhere else.
C. a war with no fighting on land.
D. a war that was over before the end of 1914.

Correct: A.

B. The Western Front was treated as the entire war.

C. The character of the war was denied.

D. The early expectation of a short war was treated as what happened.

Reteach: The Western Front mattered hugely to Britain. It was not the whole war. There was an Eastern Front, war at sea, Gallipoli, and fighting beyond Europe. Name the front you mean.

THE PEACE SETTLEMENT · 19

The Treaty of Versailles (1919)

A. limited Germany in several ways, redrew land, and set up the League of Nations. Article 231 was one clause.
B. was only the war-guilt clause.
C. was signed before the First World War.
D. left every border exactly as it was in 1914.

Correct: A.

B. A long treaty was reduced to Article 231.

C. 1919 was placed before 1914.

D. The territorial terms were denied. Land and colonies did change hands.

Reteach: Article 231 blamed Germany and was tied to reparations. The treaty also took territory, limited the armed forces, and created the League. Do not reduce it to one clause.

THE ROAD TO 1939 · 20

Which is the fairest line on why the Second World War happened?

A. Versailles fed German resentment. It was not the only cause. The Depression, Hitler's aims and the 1930s mattered too.
B. Article 231 was the only cause.
C. The treaty had no effect on anything that followed.
D. The war began in 1919, when the treaty was signed.

Correct: A.

B. One clause of 1919 was left to explain 1939 on its own.

C. A real grievance was denied. Keep it in the explanation. Do not make it the whole explanation.

D. A cause was turned into the event itself.

Reteach: A long-term grievance is not a single cause. Keep Versailles, and keep the Depression, Hitler's aims, and the decisions of the 1930s.

WEIMAR AND NAZI GERMANY · 21

Hyperinflation in 1923 and the slump after 1929 were

A. two different crises.
B. the same crisis, under two names.
C. both caused by the Wall Street Crash.
D. both the moment the Weimar Republic ended, in 1923.

Correct: A.

B. 1923 and 1929 were merged.

C. The Crash was in October 1929. It cannot explain 1923.

D. The republic survived the inflation. It did not fall in 1923.

Reteach: 1923 was the inflation, linked to the occupation of the Ruhr and the printing of money. The Crash came in October 1929, and the Depression followed. Do not merge them.

WEIMAR AND NAZI GERMANY · 22

When Hitler became chancellor in January 1933,

A. the Nazis were the largest party. They did not have a majority of seats. Hindenburg appointed him.
B. the Nazis held more than half the seats, so the job was automatic.
C. he won a direct election for president that month.
D. he took power the week after the Munich Putsch.

Correct: A.

B. Largest party was exaggerated into a majority. In November 1932 they were well short of one.

C. Chancellor and president were confused. Hindenburg was president.

D. The Putsch was 1923. The chancellorship was ten years later. The Putsch failed.

Reteach: In the November 1932 election the Nazis were the largest party and did not have a majority. Hindenburg appointed Hitler chancellor on 30 January 1933. It was not the result of holding half the seats.

WEIMAR AND NAZI GERMANY · 23

The day after the Reichstag fire (27 February 1933), the emergency decree

A. suspended important civil liberties. It did not, that morning, ban every other party.
B. banned every other party on the spot.
C. made Hitler president.
D. did nothing, because the fire was in 1939.

Correct: A.

B. Later bans were pulled forward onto the morning after the fire.

C. Hindenburg remained president. The decree was about emergency powers, not the presidency.

D. The date was moved. The fire was 27 February 1933. The decree was the next day.

Reteach: The 28 February decree swept away civil liberties and was used to detain opponents, including Communists. Other parties were forced out over the following months. The Enabling Act was in March 1933. Do not say the fire banned every party overnight.

THE 1930S · 24

British appeasement in the 1930s is best explained as

A. more than one motive: fear of another war, the memory of 1914–18, time to rearm, and a misreading of Hitler.
B. only cowardice.
C. a policy that began after 1945.
D. something Britain never tried.

Correct: A.

B. A judgement was used in place of an explanation.

C. The dates were moved. Appeasement is a 1930s policy. The war is what it failed to prevent.

D. Munich and the earlier concessions were denied.

Reteach: "Coward" is a judgement, not an explanation. Say what was feared, what was hoped, and what it cost. Memory of the last war and the need to rearm were part of it.

THE SECOND WORLD WAR · 25

Dunkirk in 1940 is best described as

A. an evacuation that got a large part of the army home, while France fell and heavy equipment was left behind.
B. a battle that defeated the German army.
C. the outbreak of the war.
D. a German evacuation from Britain.

Correct: A.

B. An evacuation was renamed a victory in the field.

C. September 1939 was moved to the summer of 1940.

D. Who was leaving, and from where, was reversed. This was the BEF leaving France.

Reteach: Operation Dynamo, late May to early June 1940, took hundreds of thousands of Allied troops off the beaches. That saved the army. It did not defeat Germany, and the equipment was lost.

THE SECOND WORLD WAR · 26

The Blitz was

A. the bombing of British cities from September 1940. It did not destroy the RAF.
B. the battle that destroyed the RAF, which is why the cities were then safe to bomb.
C. a naval battle in 1916.
D. the event that ended the war in 1940.

Correct: A.

B. The Battle of Britain and the Blitz were merged, and the RAF's survival was denied.

C. The Blitz was confused with an earlier war. Jutland was 1916. The Blitz was 1940–41.

D. The war went on until 1945. The Blitz did not end it.

Reteach: Keep two things apart. The Battle of Britain, in the summer of 1940, was the fight for control of the air. The Blitz, from September 1940, was the bombing of cities. The RAF had not been destroyed.

THE COLD WAR · 27

The Cold War is best described as

A. a long rivalry that usually avoided direct battle between US and Soviet soldiers, and was fought through alliances, arms and proxy wars.

B. a series of battles fought only by American and Soviet soldiers against each other.

C. a war that ended in 1945.

D. a period with no real violence anywhere.

Correct: A.

B. Proxy wars and the avoidance of direct superpower battle were both missed.

C. The Cold War was dated as the Second World War. 1945 is closer to a starting point than an ending.

D. "Cold" was misread as "peaceful". Korea, Vietnam and other wars were part of the rivalry.

Reteach: Direct fighting between the two superpowers was avoided. That did not make the period peaceful. Wars fought by others, with superpower backing, were part of it.

THE COLD WAR · 28

The Berlin Wall, begun in August 1961, was built to

A. stop people leaving East Germany for the West.

B. stop Westerners getting into East Berlin.

C. divide Germany for the first time.

D. keep East Berliners out of the rest of East Germany, with no concern about the West.

Correct: A.

B. The direction was reversed. The flight was from East to West.

C. Germany was already divided. The wall closed the last easy exit in Berlin.

D. The destination of the people who were leaving was missed.

Reteach: Before the wall, large numbers of East Germans left for the West through Berlin. The wall was built to stop that. It was not built to keep Western visitors out.

THE COLD WAR · 29

During the Cuban Missile Crisis in October 1962,

A. Soviet missile sites were discovered on Cuba. The missiles were not launched.

B. the Soviet Union had already fired the missiles at the United States.

C. the argument was only about the Berlin Wall.

D. the United States had placed the missiles on Cuba.

Correct: A.

B. A crisis about sites was turned into a strike that did not happen.

C. Two different crises were merged. Berlin was 1961. Cuba was 1962.

D. Who put the missiles there was reversed. They were Soviet missiles on Cuba.

Reteach: Photographs showed the sites. There was a naval blockade, then a deal: the missiles left Cuba, the United States promised not to invade, and American missiles were later removed from Turkey. The missiles were not fired.

VOTES FOR WOMEN · 30

The Representation of the People Act 1918

A. gave the vote to women over 30 who met a property qualification. It did not give it to all women.
B. gave every woman the vote on the same terms as men.
C. gave the vote to no women.
D. lowered the voting age for women to 18.

Correct: A.

B. 1918 was treated as equal franchise. That came in 1928, at the age of 21.

C. The partial reform was denied. Some women did gain the vote in 1918.

D. A later change was moved to 1918. The women's age in 1918 was 30, not 18.

Reteach: 1918 was partial: women over 30, with a property qualification. Men over 21, and servicemen from 19, were enfranchised more broadly. Women voted on the same terms as men from 1928.

EMPIRE · 31

The British Empire

A. ended in stages, over many years, not in a single year.
B. ended everywhere in one year.
C. kept growing after 1945 in the same way, with no independences.
D. never included India.

Correct: A.

B. A long process of decolonisation was collapsed into a single date.

C. Indian independence in 1947, and later independences, were denied.

D. The largest colonial possession was left out. India was part of the empire. Independence was in 1947.

Reteach: Use the dates for the places you are teaching. Indian independence in 1947 is not the same event as the end of the whole empire. There is no single year in which all of it stopped.

SLAVERY AND THE TRADE · 32

Which is accurate?

A. Britain abolished the slave trade in 1807, and slavery in most of its colonies in 1833. Neither date ended slavery everywhere.
B. The 1807 Act ended slavery everywhere, immediately.
C. Britain never abolished the trade.
D. 1833 came before 1807.

Correct: A.

B. The trade and slavery were treated as the same law, and the rest of the world was included.

C. 1807 was denied.

D. The two Acts were put in the wrong order.

Reteach: Keep the two laws apart: the trade in 1807, and slavery in British colonies in 1833. People held in those colonies were not all free on the day the 1833 Act passed, and other countries went on. Do not say the world ended slavery in 1807.

WRITING HISTORY · 33

A pupil writes “the people wanted war”. What should they do instead?

A. Say which people, and how we know. A population does not have one mind.
B. Nothing. “The people” is already precise.
C. Replace it with “everyone”, which is more precise.
D. Only use “the people” when writing about an election, where it is always accurate.

Correct: A.

B. A whole country was given a single intention.

C. A wider word was offered as the repair. It is less precise, not more.

D. Even an election return is a particular group of voters, not a single will.

Reteach: Name a group you can point at: ministers, a newspaper, recruits, voters in one election. “The people” hides the disagreement inside any country.

CAUSATION · 34

A long-term cause and a trigger are different because

A. a long-term cause builds over time, and a trigger is the event that sets things moving.
B. they are two words for the same thing.
C. a trigger always matters more than anything that came before it.
D. a long-term cause happens after the event.

Correct: A.

B. The spark and the background were collapsed.

C. The background was demoted automatically. Sometimes the spark matters less than the pressure behind it. You have to argue it.

D. The order was reversed. Long-term means before, over time.

Reteach: Keep both. An alliance can be long-term. An assassination can be the trigger. Explain the link. Do not promote the spark to the only cause, and do not ignore it.

Run one hinge in two minutes

The questions in this bank are multiple choice, so a class can show A, B, C or D on mini whiteboards. That is the fast version. You see the letter, and you reteach the line that goes with it.

If you want the sentence behind the letter, use Get It?.

1. Type the topic, or paste the question. Edit what comes back. It is your question.
2. Pupils join with the class code on a phone, a laptop, or a school device. A first name is enough. No account, and nothing to install.
3. They answer in their own words, typed or spoken. It is not multiple choice. The sentence shows the mistake more clearly than a letter does.
4. In about two minutes you get green, amber or red. The colour is guidance. It can be wrong, and you can change it.
5. Reteach the line from this bank before you move on.

Where phones are banned, do not demand a phone. Use school devices, or stay with the boards.

A first name and the answers are sent to an external AI. If school policy forbids that, do not use the tool with pupil answers. The boards still work.

Free during the beta. No card.

dotheygetit.app